Flanked by Minister of Agriculture Mikhail Gorbachev and Defence Minister Dmitriy Ustinov – Chernenko charged that the FRG was the ‘main executor’ of US policy in Europe, while the Bundeswehr had grown from an army that was formed for defence purposes ‘into the main force of NATO’. As Honecker listened in silence, Chernenko gave a sour account of West Germany’s offensive military doctrine saying Bonn and Washington acted in full agreement: ‘The US supports new missiles in Europe; called a crusade against socialism … the FRG is the executor of Reagan’s politics on our continent.’ A grey-faced Ustinov declared the course of the GDR would affect Soviet security interests and the loyalty of the National People’s Army and facilitate espionage opportunities for NATO. However, the main problem for the Soviet leadership was ‘the financial dependencies of the GDR on the FRG’. Reading from typewritten papers, Chernenko said any hopes Honecker harboured for a visit to Bonn were not desirable. ‘You ought to remember,’ he warned, ‘that the development of relations between East and West Germany must always respect the security interests of the Soviet Union first and foremost.’ Along the way, he also expressed concern that GDR foreign policy contacts with Western industrialised countries were intensifying, a reference to a January visit by the Canadian Prime Minister, Pierre Elliot Trudeau to East Berlin, and the Prime Minister of Sweden, Olof Palme’s, meeting with Honecker in Stralsund during June. The German delegation was stunned by the Soviet leader’s aggression. According to Markus Wolf, the meeting broke up in a frosty atmosphere. ‘Honecker, enraged at his humiliation, had indulged in a rare show of temper once he was alone again with his team and mocked Chernenko’s school-masterly act.’ From then on, Wolf recalled the impasse over the Bonn visit dominated all other questions with Moscow: ‘I had never known a period when things were so strained.’ East German agents listening in to a phone call between the FRG’s Press Spokesman Klaus Bolling, and another senior West German official discussing the Honecker-Chernenko spat transcribed the following brief exchange: ‘This is turning into a really big deal,’ Bolling observed, ‘It’s more exciting than Dallas and Dynasty put together!’3

Over the next few days, Honecker sulked. He cast around for a way to save his Bonn trip and found support from Romania’s Ceausescu, and Janos Kadar, the Hungarian who was highly esteemed by Brezhnev and